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‘AI is like fire’: a discourse analysis of language teachers’ attitudes towards artificial intelligence

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ABSTRACT

This study examines how language teachers talk about artificial intelligence (AI) and how that talk relates to uptake. We analysed 17 semi-structured interviews from international teachers using utterance-level appraisal, metaphor and keyword analysis and interpreted findings through TAM3 (usefulness, ease, intention, social influence) and AI-literacy domains (informed, practical, critical, ethical). Teachers’ metaphors and stance-marking language clustered into three frames: AI as terminator (integrity/assessment risks), enigma (inevitability/opacity; knowledge gaps) and sidekick (teacher-facing workflow support with human-in-the-loop boundaries). Mapping tagged utterances to a two-axis space (AI acceptance/AI literacy) yielded four attitudinal archetypes: sceptic, enthusiast, purist and early explorer. Implications are actionable: teach AI as literacies (and assess them), redesign assessment towards process evidence (draft trails, provenance checks), and stage adoption from planning to classroom implementation with explicit guardrails. Limitations include cross-sectional, self-reported data and raw-surplus profiling; future longitudinal, multilingual studies should normalise by utterance density and triangulate with classroom artefacts and traces.

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Introduction

Artificial intelligence (AI) is reshaping what language teachers do, how they plan and how learners engage with texts and tasks. Recent syntheses in applied linguistics stress both powerful affordances – automation of routine work, rapid feedback and new task designs – and unresolved concerns about ethics, equity and privacy in classroom use (Chapelle et al. 2024; Ogurlu and Mossholder 2023; Rudolph, Tan, and Tan 2023).

The rise and consolidation of generative AI (GenAI) sharpens these tensions. Tools such as large language models can streamline preparation and inspire activities, yet teachers report organisational pressure to *innovate* with digital technologies (Vazquez-Calvo, Paz-López, and Rey-Godoy 2025) amid precarious work conditions and uneven institutional support for training, conditions that can accelerate adoption without commensurate

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professional development (Ciampa, Wolfe, and Bronstein 2023; Gironzetti and Muñoz-Basols 2025; Lee, Jeon, and Choe 2025).

What teachers *say* about AI, such as the metaphors they articulate to refer to it, offers a window into how acceptance and resistance take shape in practice. A discourse-analytic lens lets us observe how teachers frame usefulness, risk and ethics in concrete terms, going beyond attitudinal inventories to examine evaluative language in context (Gee 2014; Shafiee, Susan Marandi, and Reza Mirzaeian 2022).

To connect discourse with likely uptake, we integrate the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM3), foregrounding perceived usefulness (ease, intention, individual traits and social influence, Venkatesh and Bala 2008), and AI literacy (informed, practical, critical and ethical AI knowledge, Ng et al. 2021). Read together through discourse analysis, these lenses relate *how* teachers talk about AI to *why* they might adopt or resist it. We analyse metaphors and keywords in semi-structured interviews and interpret stance-bearing utterances via TAM3 and AI literacy heuristics to move beyond cataloguing opinions towards patterned profiles of acceptance and literacy. The study is guided by two research questions:

RQ1. How does language teachers' discourse reveal underlying attitudes and perceptions towards AI's role in language education?

RQ2. What teacher attitudinal profiles emerge from analysing AI acceptance and AI literacy?

With these questions, we attempt to sharpen understanding of teachers' AI uptake to guide further teacher education and initiatives on critical AI literacies and reflective practice alongside technical skill (Ciampa, Wolfe, and Bronstein 2023) and to inform responsive policy for early-career educators. In the next section, we review teacher–AI research, introduce the TAM3 and AI literacy lens and outline our qualitative methods.

Literature review: teacher perceptions and attitudes towards AI

Much like earlier waves of educational technology (Valiente 2010), AI's arrival has polarised teachers and fuelled rapid research on perceptions and attitudes (Rudolph, Tan, and Tan 2023). Early studies consistently report AI-literacy gaps (Ogurlu and Mossholder 2023; Uwosomah and Dooly 2025; Zimotti, Frances, and Whitaker 2024) that likely slow adoption by depressing perceived usefulness and ease of use, core antecedents of uptake in TAM3 (Venkatesh and Bala 2008). Learner-focused evidence underscores the centrality of usefulness: in a survey of 405 EFL learners using ChatGPT for informal digital learning of English (IDLE), G. Liu and Ma (2023) modelled TAM links and found that ease-of-use affected attitude only via usefulness, which strongly predicted behavioural intention and actual use (59% of AU variance explained). These patterns motivate examining literacy alongside acceptance to explain the uneven pace of teachers' adoption.

Recent work has begun to move from attitudes towards measurable GenAI competence. Wu, Wang and Singh Lalli (2025) develop and validate a 21-item AI competence scale for pre-service L2 teachers with three factors (awareness and willingness, knowledge and application, and social responsibility) and then use latent profile analysis to show that future teachers cluster in partially prepared profiles (most have good awareness and ethics but thinner application skills). This provides population-level evidence that readiness for GenAI is uneven across dimensions. Our study complements this approach by showing how such unevenness is voiced in teachers' evaluative talk, for example, declared high AI literacy but low classroom acceptance.

Across contexts, teachers highlight clear affordances (workload reduction, quick access to information and assistance for lesson preparation), suggesting pragmatic, tool-oriented optimism (Ogurlu and Mossholder 2023; Uwosomah and Dooly 2025). At the same time, concerns cluster around plagiarism, detection arms-races and assessment integrity, reflecting unresolved tensions, especially in writing-intensive subjects (Rudolph, Tan, and Tan 2023; Zimotti, Frances, and Whitaker 2024). These mixed pictures indicate that attitudes are not purely dispositional but responsive to the tasks, genres and accountability regimes that teachers and learners inhabit.

Much of this literature relies on surveys and interviews that catalogue opinions. Following Hallajow's (2018) socio-cognitive view that attitudes are enacted in discourse and tied to identity work, and Gee's (2014) focus on situated meaning, we examine how teachers talk about AI, the keywords they mobilise, the metaphors they prefer and the evaluative stances they take in context. This discourse-analytic lens complements perception studies by revealing attitudes and positioning as teachers weigh usefulness, risk and ethics, signalling evolving identity orientations. Our study contributes by combining thematic and discourse analysis of interviews with a theory-led synthesis that links talk to AI acceptance and AI literacy.

Therefore, we extend prior work by (a) foregrounding AI literacy as a co-determinant of adoption alongside acceptance and (b) operationalising attitudes as discursive performances rather than static traits. This positions our analysis to explain not only *what* teachers claim to think about AI but *how* their evaluative language aligns with adoption-relevant constructs.

Theoretical framework: Technology Acceptance Model and AI literacy through discourse analysis

We treat teachers' talk about AI as situated evaluations: practical judgements grounded in lived experience, such as course design, assessment periods and school norms. In this view, attitudes are not abstract traits, but stances expressed in language: what teachers value or fear, how strongly they feel it, and how they align with colleagues or policies (Gee 2014; Martin and White 2005).

Technology Acceptance (TAM3) is our first lens. It foregrounds adoption constructs that surface in professional talk: perceived usefulness (does it help me do my job?), perceived ease of use/effort (how hard to learn/maintain?), behavioural intention/use behaviour (will/do I use it?), individual differences (e.g., self-efficacy, anxiety, playfulness) and social influence (peer/managerial norms) (Venkatesh and Bala 2008). 'It helps me plan faster' indexes usefulness; 'It's too time-consuming to learn' signals effort. TAM3 thus anchors what teachers appraise when evaluating AI. According to prior quantitative research (G. Liu and Ma 2023), learners use AI when it feels useful. From a qualitative perspective, we examine how teachers frame this in interviews, how they talk about ease, usefulness and intentions, to verify whether the pattern reported in learner studies holds true: that usefulness is the main driver of adoption.

AI literacy is our second lens. It captures the knowledge teachers draw on to judge what AI can and cannot,or should and should not-do. Adapting Ng et al. (2021), we consider four domains of knowledge: informed (what AI is/does), practical (how to use/ apply tools), critical (how to check credibility, bias, limits) and ethical knowledge (fairness, accountability, transparency, safety). These literacies matter for real-world adoption because they shape perceptions of appropriateness, affordability and risk (Mutammimah et al. 2024). For instance, 'Large models can hallucinate, so I double-check outputs' is a critical stance, and 'We anonymise student data before prompting' is an ethical one. AI literacy therefore clarifies the basis on which teachers evaluate AI. Our AI-literacy axis aligns with the three-factor structure validated for pre-service L2 teachers (awareness and willingness, knowledge and application and social responsibility) in Wu, Wang and Singh Lalli (2025). We analyse these dimensions as discourse (not self-report), interpreting profiles from attitudinal talk rather than quantifying them.

To keep meaning tied to practice, we read teachers' evaluations through a nested, cyclical lens: (1) situation first – interpret each statement in its immediate setting, as the same wording can mean different things across moments (Gee 2014); (2) stance – identify whether the evaluation is positive or negative, recognising that professional talk may report others' views as well as one's own (Martin and White 2005); (3) framing metaphors – trace recurrent mappings to distil affordances, expectations and risks (Lakoff and Johnson 2003; Nikitina and Furuoka 2008) and (4) keywords as pointers – use recurring words/ phrases (e.g. *saves time*, *undermines learning*, *black box*, *data privacy*) to locate and characterise evaluations; aiding interpretation rather than providing statistics (Rayson 2020).

Conceptualising attitudes as a two-dimensional space – acceptance (TAM3, Venkatesh and Bala 2008) and AI literacy (Ng et al. 2021) – and interpreting them through situated meaning and stance (Gee 2014; Martin and White 2005), we propose a theoretical map (not a causal model) that supports attitudinal profiles (e.g. high-acceptance/high-literacy 'enthusiasts', low-acceptance/high-literacy 'sceptics') without essentialising individuals. Analytically, these lenses are brought together through a sequenced interpretative procedure in which teachers' discourse is first examined for evaluative language (keywords, metaphors, appraisal) and subsequently interpreted to identify patterns of AI acceptance and AI literacy at the utterance level (see Methods, Phase 3). Discourse is thus treated as attitude enactment (Hallajow 2018), attending not simply to what is said but to how evaluations are articulated in professional talk.

Combining TAM3 and AI literacy is theoretically coherent and substantively productive. TAM3 foregrounds what teachers appraise when deciding whether to adopt a technology (e.g. usefulness, effort, strategic value, social influence) (Venkatesh and Bala 2008), whereas AI-literacy frameworks specify what teachers need to know and be able to do to judge AI's credibility, limits and responsible use (Ng et al. 2021). In language teacher education contexts, these dimensions are mutually informative: teachers may endorse AI in principle yet lack the critical or ethical resources to use it responsibly, or they may be highly literate about risks while withholding adoption in the absence of assessment and policy clarity. Reading acceptance and literacy together therefore provides a more complete account of uptake than either lens alone, aligning with emerging evidence that

GenAI readiness is multidimensional and better understood through profiles rather than a single pro/anti stance (Wu, Wang, and Singh Lalli 2025).

Materials and methods

This is a qualitative-interpretative, interview-based study (Cohen, Manion, and Morrison 2007) analysing responses from 17 language teachers, during the emergence of AI, to two core questions: 'How do you see AI influencing language teaching and learning?' and 'How is AI influencing your own teaching or learning?' (Vazquez-Calvo and Paz Lopez 2025). Participant demographics follow.

Participants

We used purposive sampling via contacts through an international project: faculty teaching language-teaching master's programmes invited current and former students by email and personal outreach and interested volunteers enrolled. The sample included 17 participants (6 men, 11 women) from nine countries (Brazil, China, Iran, Ireland, Portugal, Spain, Sweden, the United Kingdom and the United States) aged 22–44 (median = 31). Eleven were junior (≤5 years' teaching) and six non-junior (>5 years). All had backgrounds in linguistics or language education. Full demographics appear in Table 1.

Data collection

Over 6 months we conducted 17 in-depth interviews (2 in person, 15 online), dual-device recorded (phone or laptop, and tablet), lasting 35–72 min ($M = 54.5$) (full data collection details appear in Table 2). Transcripts were generated with HappyScribe and manually checked; because prosody was not central, we used orthographic transcription and focused on content, lexical choice and metaphors. Interviews were in Spanish ($n = 11$) and English ($n = 6$); bilingual researchers coded and analysed the original-language transcripts. Quoted excerpts were translated by the authors and back-read by a bilingual author to preserve metaphor entailments and appraisal values.

Instruments

In this study, we rely primarily on semi-structured interview data, collected with a 14-topic protocol adapted from Shafiee, Susan Marandi and Reza Mirzaeian (2022) and validated by two independent experts, both applied linguists and language professors, supplemented by brief follow-up chats and participant screenshots (Vazquez-Calvo and Paz Lopez 2025).

Data analysis

We used a three-phase procedure: (1) thematic coding to surface recurrent affordances and concerns; (2) discourse analysis of metaphors, keywords and appraisal at the utterance level and (3) a theory-led synthesis, mapping evidence to TAM3 and AI literacy

Table 1. Participants' demographics (*marks non-junior participants).

Participant	Gender	Age	Residence	Academic background	LT (years)	Sector	Language taught
P1	M	24	ES	BA English MA Teaching (EN)	<1	Tutoring Practicum	English Spanish
P2	M	24	ES	BA English MA Teaching (EN)	<1	Practicum	English
P3	F	36	ES	BA English MA Teaching (English)	5	Tutoring Private Practicum	English
P4	F	25	ES	BA English	<1	Tutoring	English
P5	F	31	ES	BA English MA Teaching (EN)	4	Tutoring Private Practicum	Spanish
P6	M	25	BR	BA Spanish	<1	Seeker	Spanish
P7	M	35	CN	BA TEFL MA British Studies/International Relations/Irish Studies PhD European Studies	4	University	Irish
P8*[1]	F	28	ES	BA Preschool and Primary Education	10	Tutoring Private Practicum	English
P9*	F	29	IE	BA Translation (ES-EN) MA Teaching PhD Linguistics	8	Practicum Secondary Education University	Spanish
P10*	F	36	IR	BA Translation (EN) MA Teaching	15	Practicum Tutoring Private	English
P11	F	22	PT	BA Modern Languages (EN-ES) MA Teaching	<1	Tutoring	English
P12	M	28	UK	BA Translation, Modern Languages and Communication (ES-FR) MA Applied Translation Studies PhD Translation	4	University	Spanish
P13*	M	29	UK	BA English MA Applied Linguistics (ELE) PhD Linguistics	6	Practicum University	Spanish
P14*	F	49	SE	BA Psychology MA English	7	Private	English Swedish
P15	F	27	SE	BA/MA Teaching MA English	3.5	Secondary Education	English
P16	F	28	UK	BA English MA Teaching (EN)	5	Practicum Tutoring Private University	Spanish English French
P17*	F	44	US	BA Sociology MA Teaching (EN)	8	Secondary Education	English

Table 2. Data collection.

Participant	Interview language	Length (min)	Words transcribed
P1	ES	61	9387
P2	ES	48	6954
P3	ES	43	7496
P4	ES	35	6336
P5	ES	52	8795
P6	ES	55	6363
P7	EN	72	9477
P8	ES	51	8814
P9	ES	61	8289
P10	EN	63	7102
P11	EN	66	8038
P12	ES	47	6364
P13	ES	42	5900
P14	EN	53	7797
P15	EN	55	7066
P16	ES	59	9483
P17	EN	64	10,220

domains. This integrates what teachers say with how they say it, yielding a multidimensional account of attitudes and practices. Utterance-level analysis follows the conceptual underpinnings presented in the theoretical framework.

Phase 1. Thematic analysis

We thematically coded interview transcripts on digital technologies in language education (Creswell and David Creswell 2018). AI surfaced persistently, prompting targeted items in the interview protocol. We also noted recurrent, emic metaphors for AI, motivating a focused Phase 2: discourse analysis.

Phase 2. Discourse analysis

Guided by situated meaning, that is, context-bound sense-making (Gee 2014), we analysed how participants talked about AI in ATLAS.ti, focusing on three features:

(1) Keywords (Rayson 2020). We flagged salient lexical items (e.g. bias, magic, cheat), read them with their surrounding words to establish situated meaning (Gee 2014), and then grouped them thematically as AI as terminator, AI as enigma, or AI as sidekick.
(2) Metaphors (Lakoff and Johnson 2003; Nikitina and Furuoka 2008). We identified non-literal expressions (e.g. 'AI is like fire'), including simile (an explicit like/as comparison), personification (attributing human traits/agency to AI, e.g., 'AI decides/knows') and metonymy (naming a whole by a related part/attribute, e.g., 'the algorithm' for an AI system). We checked the literal sense and then inferred entailments – the expectations or consequences a metaphor invites (e.g., fire = helpful yet potentially destructive) – before assigning items to the same three families (terminator/enigma/sidekick) (Gee 2014; Nikitina and Furuoka 2008).
(3) Stance at the utterance level (Krasina 2016). For each utterance (a complete spoken idea), we examined how linguistic choices (keywords, metaphors, appraisal resources) positioned AI positively or negatively; these utterances were then

coded for AI acceptance and AI literacy patterns, forming the basis for participant profiling (see Phase 3).

Phase 3. Integration of frameworks

At the utterance level, we integrated results from the preceding thematic and discourse analyses with two frameworks: AI acceptance and AI literacy. That is, each interview utterance about AI presenting evaluative force (keywords, metaphors and appraisal) was coded for AI acceptance (Venkatesh and Bala 2008), using items 1–6 listed in Table 3; and for AI literacy (Ng et al. 2021), using items 7–10. Each utterance could satisfy multiple items and was double-coded for AI acceptance and AI literacy using binary polarity tags (+/–) (Martin and White 2005).

Coders assigned all applicable tags before computing polarity. We excluded a neutral category, as neutrality in literacy was not meaningfully operationalisable. Two analytic examples follow:

- Positive valence. 'I think [AI] could be a very valuable tool for understanding plagiarism' was tagged as positive acceptance (+) for valuable tool (indicates perceived usefulness per TAM3, in that the participant relates AI to enhanced job performance) and positive literacy (+) for understanding what AI can do (indicates use as the participant applies AI to a concrete task: understanding/detecting plagiarism).
- Negative valence. 'I don't know much about [AI] . . . I'm more conservative' received negative acceptance (–) for self-identifying as conservative (as it indicates behavioural intention as reluctance to use and an individual difference, the conservative stance signalling trait-based hesitation) and negative literacy (–) for 'don't know much' (indicating a low degree of the 'Know and understanding AI' item, as it shows limited self-reported knowledge).

Regarding scoring and plotting, we tallied each participant's '+'/'–' tags per axis and computed raw surplus scores (positives minus negatives). To preserve contribution density, we did not normalise, and variability from verbosity was retained as meaningful.

Table 3. Operational questions for utterance coding of AI acceptance (TAM3) and AI literacy.

Framework	Item	Construct	Operational Question
TAM3	1	Perceived usefulness	Indicates AI would enhance job performance?
	2	Perceived ease of use	Indicates AI would be free of effort to use?
	3	Behavioural intention	Indicates intention to use AI (linked to usefulness/ease)?
	4	Use behaviour	Indicates actual use, shaped by intention/facilitating conditions?
	5	Individual differences	References self-efficacy, anxiety, playfulness, etc., affecting acceptance?
	6	Social influence	References norms/image/others' views affecting the decision to use AI?
AI literacy	7	Know and understand AI	Shows knowledge of AI functions and basic applications?
	8	Use and apply AI	Shows application across scenarios of AI concepts/tools?
	9	Evaluate and create AI	Shows higher-order work with AI (evaluate/appraise/predict/design)?
	10	AI ethics	Shows human-centred concerns (fairness, accountability, transparency, ethics, safety)?

Surplus scores were plotted as x = acceptance and y = AI literacy in Figure 2, yielding approximate ranges −30 to 30 (acceptance) and −50 to 50 (literacy). Points were displaced from the origin by the surplus magnitude (for example, three more '+' than '–' on acceptance = +3 on x). The axes define four quadrants, which underpin the attitudinal archetypes reported in Findings: AI profiling based on TAM3 and AI Literacy.

The first and second authors independently coded every utterance for AI acceptance and AI literacy, achieving 91% raw agreement and Cohen's $\kappa = .82$ ($p < 0.001$), indicating 'substantial' agreement (Landis and Gary 1977). A reconciliation session increased agreement to 99%, with the third author adjudicating remaining discrepancies.

Participants were informed about aims, data use and possible publication and gave voluntary consent with the option to withdraw at any time. All data were anonymised and handled confidentially (University of Malaga Research Ethics Committee No. 113-2022-H).

Findings

We present discourse-analytic findings and themes, illustrated with participant (P) quotes (Q). We then integrate these findings with TAM3 and AI literacy to explain language teachers' attitudes towards AI. Quotes are marked by single comas and metaphors within them are in italics for emphasis. Keywords and key phrases are italised to distinguish them as linguistic objects.

Discourse-mediated attitudes and perceptions towards AI

Across the 17 interviews, we coded stance-bearing utterances containing metaphors (n = 41) and expressions including keywords with prominent choice of adjectives ($n = 78$), nouns ($n = 72$), verbs ($n = 69$) and adverbs ($n = 9$), revealing attitudes and dispositions towards AI in language education. Figure 1 depicts a word cloud of all n-grams in the dataset as a meaning-making visualisation. Font size corresponds to relative frequency, highlighting recurring thematic concepts.

Despite wide variation and little repetition, consistent patterns surfaced. Metaphors and keywords clustered into three emic, inductively derived themes – AI as terminator, enigma and sidekick – each elaborated through conceptual codes. These themes align with an acceptance gradient, from least accepting (terminator) to most welcoming (sidekick) (see Discussion), indicating participant discourse-based attitudes towards AI.

AI as terminator

Generative AI raised serious concerns for participants, who saw it as a threat to professional roles and traditional assessment. Their discourse often framed AI as destructive, unlawful or infiltrating. For example, for many language teachers in the dataset (6) AI represents a force of destruction in education:

> Well, I think AI *is going to be the fire of school*. It's going to be *the fire of education* because, above all, it's going to burn us teachers. In the sense that it's both very good and very bad at the same time. It's very bad because of the issue with plagiarism and the issue of "the chat does it for me, it's easier". But it's very good because we can harness it. We can exploit it a lot. (P1Q1)

Figure 1. Word cloud of all interview n-grams (Tokens and multiword expressions).

This metaphor, which conveys both devastation and renewal aligns with a broader perception that AI could not only dismantle existing educational structures but also pave the way for a new era of technology-driven language education. Language teachers' reactions to AI's capabilities, such as 'the face of the language teacher was *a poem*' (P1Q2), literally encompass *concern*, *worry*, *absolute terror* and *collective hysteria*.

These expressions were uttered mostly when connecting AI with plagiarism and writing. AI is perceived to unlawfully copy from users and operate deep fakes: 'it *can copy your image*, *it can use your picture* and *make it move your mouth*, it looks like you have said something, when really, you haven't' (P4Q1), 'so, essentially *they're plagiarising* from you' (P11Q1). This aligns with an apprehension among language educators regarding academic integrity, with essay writing remaining a standardised assessment instrument (Rudolph, Tan, and Tan 2023). AI can now generate complete essays on demand, allowing students to 'prompt AI for an essay and it will *spit it out*' (P17Q1), leaving teachers *breathless* before an untraceable piece of writing. While this study is qualitative in nature, notable keyword frequency reinforces these concerns: *plagiarism* ($n = 9$), *copy* – often collocating with *paste* –($n = 16$), *detect* ($n = 6$) and *cheat* ($n = 5$). The prevalence of these terms underscores widespread anxiety, with some participants contemplating AI's *prohibition*. Other participants share milder feelings of *wariness, worry* or *concern* and propose the need for students' use of AI *to be limited*, asserting teachers' traditional position as gatekeepers of knowledge.

AI as terminator also evokes meanings close to AI as an infiltrator – an entity that has gradually embedded itself into educational spaces as P1 illustrates: 'It has already *arrived at school corridors*. Actually, it *arrived at the corridors long ago*. Teachers simply didn´t know it yet' (Q3). Metaphors such as P1's or P3's 'ChatGPT is the *elephant in the room'* (Q1), depict AI as a conspicuously present yet intentionally disregarded reality. This metaphorical framing suggests that among language educators AI remains a controversial and somewhat taboo subject. Additionally, AI as an infiltrator also frames AI as a usurper. Language teachers share their fears of being *replaced* as 'in the end *machines will govern the world* and *steal most of our jobs*' (P3Q2), revealing a sense of unease regarding AI's impact on their roles and relationships with their students.

AI as enigma

A neutral stance arises among language teachers who neither embrace nor reject AI but rather regard it as an unstoppable force and an enigmatic entity. As an unstoppable force, AI is qualified as *the future* (P14Q1), or *a new reality* (P9Q1) or, as P3 reports:

> Right now, *it's very much in the air*. I'm not going to lie about it, I don't know a lot about it, so I don't know where its limits are. But I know that this is not going away, it's only going to get bigger. That's what we need, *this is just the beginning*. (Q3)

These expressions evoke a sense of inevitability, instability and resignation, reflecting participants' beliefs that AI's capabilities and its role in language education will only become more prevalent over time. As an enigmatic entity, participants report a 'fear of *the unknown*' (P5Q1) as 'we've barely *scratched the surface*' (P15Q1). These metaphoric framings highlight a common struggle among language teachers: lack of AI literacy. The novelty of AI tools, resembling 'an *experiment*' (P3Q4), coupled with this limited literacy leads some participants to express, in seven individual utterances, the need to study or research AI, which they report 'it'*s too new a thing* and it still needs *to be investigated*' (P1Q4)

AI as sidekick

All participants acknowledged AI's potential in language education, while recognising its limitations, and affirming the teachers' role in the classroom. There is consensus among participants that AI in language teaching is *useful* and an *inspiration*: 'it gives you the opportunity to plan the lessons [. . .] much easier' (P10Q1) and helps them perform daily tasks *faster*. There is a tendency among participants that have not used AI as a teaching aid to regard it as a powerful search engine or a '*Google on steroids*' (P1Q5). To other more AI-savvy participants, AI 'is like *your assistant as a teacher, as a non-teaching teacher*'(P10Q2), an indispensable teaching companion. Moreover, participants identified two primary applications of AI in language teaching: (1) design-oriented uses (lesson planning, activity organisation and content adaptation) and (2) practice-oriented implementations (code-switching support, keyword prompting and grammar correction).

An exception is P7's sociolinguistic angle, advocating AI for preservation: 'to *protect* the minority language that could be in danger or even extinct [. . .] it could even *revive* a language that it was long forgotten' (P7Q1). While some celebrate AI's creativity, 'create a banana bus' (P5Q2), as playful vocabulary work, others contest its communicative value, 'it'*s not communicating*, it's *not saying* anything. It's doing it beautifully, but it's not saying anything' (P14Q2) and reassert human-centred teaching.

Drawing on AI's limitations, language teachers express their frustrations and ascertain their position as experts. 'AI *is shit*' (P8Q1), 'AI *is not the panacea*' and 'I can ask it to *give me a foot massage* and it won't do it, it needs supervision' (P1Q6), or 'the ChatGPT thingy *said* "here are five sources" and *he made them up'* (P14Q3) highlight AI's perceived drawbacks. Language teachers urge their future students to 'use your mind because it's way more clever [sic] than AI will ever be' (P14Q4). The implication is, thus, that in *'ChatGPT's kitchen'* (P1Q7), AI is useless without the mediation of the expert teacher, the chef. Therefore, while participants appreciate AI's capabilities to assist in language teaching, they are also keenly aware of its constraints, and the prevailing importance of their role in the language classroom.

AI profiling based on TAM and AI literacy

We polarity-coded utterances for AI acceptance (Venkatesh and Bala 2008) and AI literacy (Ng et al. 2021) based on participants' keywords, metaphors and appraisal, then aggregated per participant. Positions were plotted in Figure 2 (x = acceptance, y = literacy; see Methods, Phase 3). Most clustered in Quadrant A (n = 8, low acceptance, high literacy) or

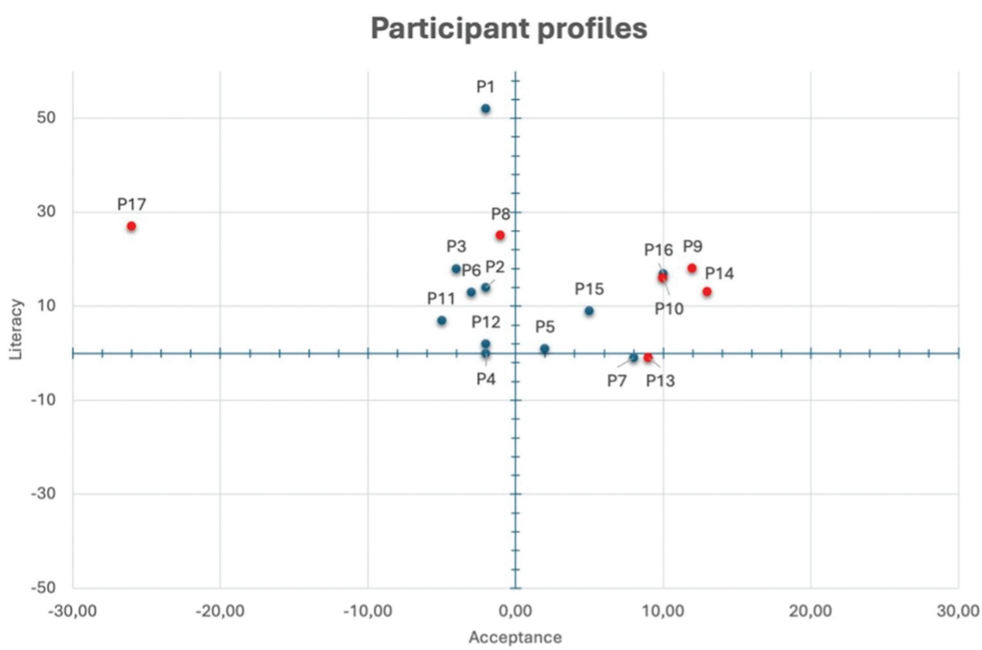

Figure 2. Participant positions on acceptance (x) and AI literacy (y).

Quadrant B ($n = 6$, high acceptance, high literacy). One participant lay near Quadrant C (low acceptance, low literacy) and two in Quadrant D (high acceptance, low literacy). To illustrate, juniors ($n = 11$) are shown in blue and non-juniors ($n = 6$) in red.

In our dataset, most non-junior teachers lean towards acceptance, with two exceptions: P8 slightly negative and P17 strongly negative. By contrast, most juniors ($n = 7$) tilt against acceptance, many near the neutral axis. We make no causal claim, but the pattern tentatively links experience to greater openness to AI experimentation. For juniors still consolidating classroom routines and methodologies, adding AI can feel like an extra burden in already demanding first years (see Discussion). Scoring and plotting on the TAM3 and AI literacy axes yields a four-quadrant interpretative matrix of AI language-teacher profiles (Figure 3): enthusiast, early explorer, sceptic, purist.

The enthusiast

Language teachers in this group ($n = 6$) exhibit high acceptance, and moderate-to-high self-reported AI literacy. They frame AI as sidekick despite occasional negative perceptions. A positive association emerges between their self-assessed literacy and acceptance: non-junior teachers ($n = 3$) showing greater preparedness (e.g., P9, who advocates for teaching ethical AI use and 'accepting it *as a new reality*' [P9Q1]) express stronger interest in further exploration. However, enthusiasm varies, with many restricting AI's utility to teachers' work (e.g. lesson planning) while remaining cautious about pedagogical practice or autonomous use among students.

The early explorer

This group ($n = 2$, both university professors, one junior and one non-junior) displays high acceptance but low literacy, driven by curiosity to try out AI tools even without fully grasping their mechanics. Their academic roles may foster openness towards technology acceptance, exemplified by P13's assertion that AI 'can be a great tool in a near future'

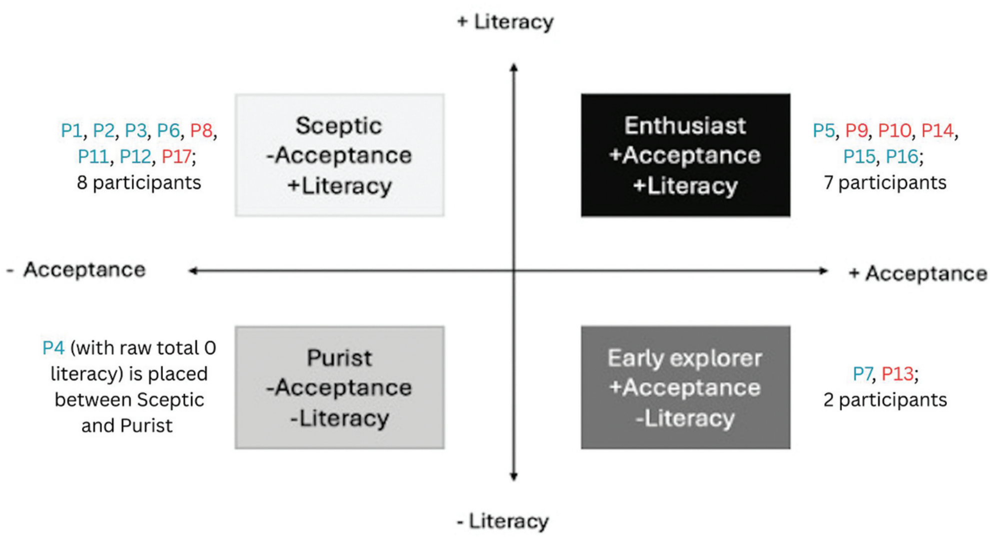

Figure 3. Four teacher archetypes from Figure 2.

(P13Q1). While they actively explore applications, their limited self-declared technical understanding suggests a need for targeted training to bridge literacy gaps.

The sceptic

Language teachers as sceptics ($n = 8$) show certain self-perceived AI literacy yet low acceptance, voicing ethical or instructional concerns or uncertainty. Most adopt a cautious stance viewing AI as a disruptive threat to learning environments or a time-consuming burden. A notable case is P17, a non-junior teacher who despite displaying high AI literacy, adamantly refuses to integrate it in her teaching, citing long-term risks of AI implementation: 'A *huge concern*' and relating to college applications: 'in the past, I thought, "Oh, my kids will be good, they're good writers. They'll be able to write a smashing essay". That's going to be all gone' (P17Q2). However, most participants in this group remain ambivalent yet leaning towards non-acceptance with academic honesty as the root of their apprehensions.

The purist

Language teachers as purists report low acceptance and minimal AI literacy, dismissing AI as irrelevant to their teaching. In our study, only one participant came close to fitting the profile. P4 was anchored in the axis on literacy, despite self-identifying as tech-savvy. Her discourse revolving classroom practices revealed underdeveloped digital and AI literacy, compounded by reliance on colleagues' negative perceptions of AI, resulting in pronounced apprehension towards AI adoption.

Together, these archetypes show how language teachers differently navigate AI's irruption: acceptance and literacy combine in varied ways to produce distinct discourse-based attitudes with potential classroom-based orientations. We now unpack what these profiles reveal about implications in the Discussion.

Discussion

Addressing RQ1, teachers' metaphors and keywords cluster into terminator, enigma and sidekick, which signal stances on usefulness, risk and ethics. Addressing RQ2, mapping utterance-level tags onto acceptance (TAM3) and AI literacy axes yields enthusiast, early explorer, sceptic and purist archetypes, clarifying how stance and self-perceived competence co-pattern. We analysed 17 interviews at the utterance level, surfacing recurring linguistic choices used to guide, not determine, interpretation.

What discourse reveals about stance (RQ1)

Situated language is diagnostic, not ornamental. Ambivalence, taboo and infiltration surface as teachers weigh benefits against harms ('AI is going to be *the fire of education* ... it's both very good and very bad' [P1Q1]; 'the *elephant in the room*' [P3Q1]; 'already *arrived to school corridors*' [P1Q3]). Functional boosterism ('*Google on steroids*', P1Q5) coexists with critical boundary-setting ('it's *not communicating* ... it's doing it beautifully, but it's not saying anything', P14Q2). This practical and critical split mirrors public AI discourse (Gupta et al. 2024) and aligns with discourse-as-identity accounts (Gee 2014; Varghese et al. 2005), where metaphors index positionality and community affiliation (Nikitina and Furuoka 2008; Uchida, Cavanagh, and Moloney 2019). The identity tension is consequential: pressures to 'innovate' collide with conservative pedagogical stances, especially among junior teachers (Vazquez-Calvo, Paz-López, and Rey-Godoy 2025). Practically, the terminator–enigma–sidekick profiles diagnose the binding constraint: assessment/ethics (terminator), knowledge/confidence (enigma) or workflow (sidekick).

From discourse to attitudinal profiles (RQ2)

Anchored in TAM3 and AI literacy (Ng et al. 2021; Venkatesh and Bala 2008), our discourse-derived profiles align with person-centred quantitative work. Wu, Wang and Singh Lalli (2025) also report large groups of pre-service L2 teachers who are willing and ethically alert yet under-skilled in application; Saeli et al. (2025) produced similar findings where younger teachers felt threatened to use GenAI, while teachers with more experience regarded GenAI as supplementary help rather than a threat; our 'sceptics' occupy the same corner, they know, they care, but they hesitate to use. Methodologically, their profiles are survey-driven; ours are talk-driven. Both point to the same bottleneck: application/practical use.

Our high-acceptance/high-literacy 'enthusiasts' map neatly onto TAM's usefulness-driven pathway, where positive attitudes align with intention and uptake; conversely, low-acceptance/high-literacy 'sceptics' foreground risks and limits (ethical/critical literacy) that depress perceived usefulness in practice. This converges with G. Liu and Ma (2023): usefulness, rather than ease alone, shapes attitude and downstream intention and behaviour.

Using raw-surplus tags (Figure 2), we observe (1) enthusiasts with sidekick-dominant talk, concrete planning/adaptation and ethical guardrails – literacy legitimises use (Ng et al. 2021); (2) early explorers whose acceptance outruns literacy – curious, low-risk pilots (e.g. 'Google on steroids') before deeper critical practice; (3) sceptics, where critical/ethical literacy raises perceived risk (plagiarism, authorship, assessment), so adoption is withheld pending clearer assessment/policy (Ogurlu and Mossholder 2023; Rudolph, Tan, and Tan 2023) and (4) purists with low acceptance and literacy, often voiced through human-first identity narratives (e.g. 'use your mind . . . ' P14Q4). An exploratory career-stage gradient (more non-juniors on the accepting right side) likely reflects contextual mediation – policy clarity, job security and norms – rather than age or tenure per se.

If usefulness mediates movement from curiosity to classroom use, professional development should begin with concrete, local gains (e.g. faster planning, clearer criteria, targeted feedback) and make those gains visible, while simultaneously building critical/ethical AI literacy so acceptance grows responsibly, which is precisely the lever identified by G. L. Liu and Wang (2023) for language learners. Translating learner-side TAM evidence into teacher practice targets the factor most likely to shift attitudes and sustained use.

Wu, Wang and Singh Lalli (2025) show that most pre-service L2 teachers are already aware and endorse ethical use but lag in knowledge. Our discourse profiles reveal the same bottleneck and explain why teachers hesitate (threat metaphors, policy anxieties, student-data worries). Professional development should therefore start from existing awareness/responsibility and move to guided, low-risk application tasks, not generic AI introductions.

Accordingly, programmes should:

- teach AI as literacies, not just tools – pair informed/practical know-how (prompt–verify–document; provenance checks) with critical/ethical lenses (bias, hallucination, accountability) and assess these literacies (Dooly and Ana 2025; Ng et al. 2021);
- redesign assessment with process evidence – draft trails, oral defence, annotated prompts, source checks and clear AI-use policies – to address terminator concerns that cluster around product-only essays (Ciampa, Wolfe, and Bronstein 2023; Rudolph, Tan, and Tan 2023; Zimotti, Frances, and Whitaker 2024);
- stage adoption using clear models, such as planning–personalisation–implementation, enabling early explorers to build literacy and sceptics to participate without identity threat (Mizza and Fernando 2025; Muñoz-Basols, Gutiérrez, and Cerezo 2025, 2025);
- tackle norms, not only skills – social influence and precarity can fast-track superficial uptake without training (Gironzetti and Muñoz-Basols 2025; Lee, Jeon, and Choe 2025);
- invest in policy clarity and collegial discourse.

TAM3 determinants are context- and task-sensitive, not stable traits. The same speaker can say 'the raw material ChatGPT gives you is useless' (P1Q8) and 'he will *chew* it for you' (P1Q9), reflecting (mis)fit with task and workflow framing. Emotion modulates intention – 'fear of the unknown' (P5Q1), 'we've barely scratched the surface' (P15Q1) – consistent with identity–emotion–agency links (Truong, Cong-Lem, and Li 2025) and adoption work tying thinner literacy to mixed uptake (Li et al. 2024; Mutammimah et al. 2024). Where AI is 'the elephant in the room' (P3Q1), reluctance hardens; where peers exchange teacher-facing workflows, curiosity grows. Assessment regimes can amplify or dampen terminator talk and promote or depress AI-as-sidekick possibilities.

Much prior work in AI and teacher education has mapped attitudes often treating acceptance and competence and literacy as adjacent rather than integrated constructs (G. Liu and Ma 2023; Wu, Wang, and Singh Lalli 2025). Our contribution is to show how these dimensions co-pattern in teachers' evaluative discourse – not only in what teachers claim, but in how they frame AI through stance and recurrent metaphors. A discourse lens grounded in situated meaning and appraisal (Gee 2014; Martin and White 2005) captures the contextual, task-sensitive nature of acceptance judgements that can be missed when constructs are measured as stable traits, while metaphor analysis makes visible the implicit framings (e.g. threat vs. assistance) that organise risk/benefit reasoning (Lakoff and Johnson 2003; Nikitina and Furuoka 2008). This approach complements TAM findings that usefulness is decisive for adoption (G. Liu and Ma 2023) and helps interpret profile-based readiness patterns reported in GenAI competence work (Wu, Wang, and Singh Lalli 2025) by explaining why otherwise willing teachers may stall at application or, conversely, why enthusiastic uptake may require critical/ethical guardrails (Ng et al. 2021).

Limitations

This study has several limits: (1) cross-sectional, self-reported data capture perceived – not observed – competence; add longitudinal classroom observation for triangulation; (2) L1-

shaped metaphors (e.g. Spanish idioms) signal cultural-linguistic effects in AI discourse and possible shifts in attitudes/identities, hence the need for multilingual samples (Darvin and Norton 2015); (3) international diversity enriches yet complicates comparability; use homogeneous cohorts or structured multi-site designs to sharpen contrasts and generalisability; (4) discourse profiling may overweight talkative participants – mitigate by normalising for speaking time/utterances, setting minimum-turn thresholds and triangulating with artefacts and fieldnotes; (5) self-selected volunteers were likely more tech-curious than the broader teacher population and (6) a single interview is a snapshot – employ repeated measures and longitudinal/ethnographic observation to track co-evolving AI literacy, acceptance and professional identity over time.

In sum, metaphors and keywords diagnose how teachers balance value, risk and ethics. Read through TAM3 and AI literacy, they illuminate swift uptake versus hesitation. Rather than pathologising caution, programmes should teach responsible literacies, redesign assessment and stage adoption so language teachers – and teachers generally – can experiment without compromising pedagogical integrity.

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